

Mobility Assimilation across Spatial Scales: Evidence from U.S. Immigrant Generations

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Abstract

Using CPS ASEC microdata and ACS state-level data, this paper examines how internal mobility varies across immigrant generations and geographic margins. First-generation respondents are more likely to move across states, whereas second-generation respondents resemble those with US-born parents on average but are less mobile at finer geographic scales. This average similarity masks heterogeneity by parental nativity: interstate mobility is lower among respondents with two foreign-born parents and higher among those with exactly one. Conditional on interstate migration, high-skilled second-generation flows exhibit weaker distance decay than native-parentage flows, indicating broader geographic reach despite similar mobility rates. PPML gravity estimates show that immigrant and co-origin presence are positively associated with destination choice across immigrant generations, but co-origin presence does not attenuate distance decay. Thus, immigrant assimilation differs across the propensity, distance, and destination margins of spatial mobility.

1 Introduction

Economic opportunities are unevenly distributed across the United States. The place in which an individual grows up and works can have persistent effects on earnings, employment, and intergenerational economic mobility Abramitzky, Boustan, Jácome, et al. 2019; Chetty, Hendren, Kline, et al. 2014; Chetty, Hendren, and Katz 2016; Chetty and Hendren 2018. Spatial mobility provides one mechanism through which workers can respond to these geographic inequalities. By moving, individuals may

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gain access to stronger labor markets, improve the quality of their job matches, and expand their opportunities for wage and occupational progression. Because relocation can also affect housing, education, and other household members, its consequences extend beyond the worker making the migration decision.

Internal migration also contributes to aggregate labor-market adjustment. Migration flows can reallocate workers following geographically concentrated economic shocks, limit the persistence of regional disparities, and improve the allocation of labor across locations Barro et al. 1991; George J. Borjas 2001; Cadena and Kovak 2016; Basso and Peri 2020; Amior 2025. Immigrants play a particularly important role in this process. Because foreign-born workers tend to respond more strongly than US-born workers to geographic differences in labor demand, they can act as "spatial arbitrageurs", moving towards locations where employment opportunities are relatively more abundant Cadena 2014; Basso and Peri 2020; East et al. 2023.

It is less clear whether this distinctive spatial responsiveness persists across immigrant generations. Research on internal migration generally compares foreign-born and US-born workers, thereby including the US-born children of immigrants in the native population. This classification implicitly assumes that second-generation workers exhibit the same spatial behavior as US-born workers with US-born parents. Yet the literature on immigrant assimilation shows that the second generation occupies a distinctive position in the intergenerational adjustment process. The children of immigrants commonly experience substantial improvements in education, occupations, and earnings relative to their parents, while their outcomes do not necessarily coincide with those of workers without a recent family history of migration George J Borjas 1992; George J Borjas 1993; Abramitzky, Boustan, and Eriksson 2014; Duncan and Trejo 2018; Abramitzky, Boustan, Jácome, et al. 2019. Treating the second generation as part of the native population may therefore conceal an important spatial dimension of economic assimilation.

A small literature has examined the geographic outcomes of the second and 1.5 generations, including their migration rates, residential dispersion, and location patterns Ellis and Goodwin-White 2006; Goodwin-White 2007; Schündeln 2014; Braun and Görts 2025. However, to the best of my knowledge, existing research has not jointly examined how the propensity to move, the geographic reach of migration, and the economic and network characteristics of destinations vary across immigrant generations and skill groups. This paper addresses this gap by studying intergenerational assimilation in spatial mobility rather than treating mobility differences as an outcome without economic or geographic content.

Spatial mobility has several distinct margins. The extensive margin captures whether an individual moves. Conditional on moving, the distance margin describes

how strongly geographic distance constrains the set of feasible destinations. A third margin concerns the characteristics of the selected destination, including its wages, population, and immigrant networks relative to the origin. These margins need not evolve together. Two groups may have similar probabilities of moving across states while differing substantially in the distances they travel or in their responsiveness to economic opportunities at alternative destinations. Distinguishing among these margins is therefore necessary to understand the economic meaning of intergenerational differences in mobility.

Three competing mechanisms may shape the spatial behavior of the second generation. First, institutional assimilation may produce convergence towards the mobility patterns of US-born workers with US-born parents. Being born and educated in the United States gives the children of immigrants greater familiarity with US institutions, nationally transferable human capital, and access to information about labor markets outside their place of residence. These factors may reduce the distinctive constraints faced by foreign-born workers.

Second, migration aspirations and attitudes may be transmitted across generations. Immigrant parents have already undertaken a costly migration and may transmit information, preferences, or aspirations that make their children more willing to search for opportunities beyond the local labor market. Under this mechanism, the second generation may retain some of the spatial responsiveness observed among foreign-born workers even while converging towards natives in other socioeconomic dimensions.

Third, immigrant networks can either constrain or facilitate mobility. Networks located at the origin may provide employment information, informal insurance, and other location-specific amenities that increase the cost of leaving Bartel 1989; Munshi 2003. Conversely, networks located at potential destinations can reduce the informational and social costs of migration and make otherwise distant locations more accessible Bertoli and Ruyssen 2018. The relevant incentive therefore depends on the strength of a network at the destination relative to the origin. This dual role makes networks a potential source of both geographic persistence and mobility across immigrant generations.

These mechanisms are also likely to vary with human capital. High-skilled workers generally participate in more geographically extensive labor markets, are better able to bear the fixed costs of relocation, and may need to search across locations to access specialized employment opportunities. Lower-skilled workers face migration costs that are larger relative to their expected gains and may depend more heavily on local information, family ties, and community networks. Comparisons that pool skill groups may consequently obscure meaningful differences in intergenerational spatial adjustment.

Against this background, the paper addresses three related questions. First, does the spatial responsiveness of foreign-born workers persist into the second generation, and does this persistence vary with human capital? Second, do second-generation workers converge towards US-born workers with US-born parents in both their probability of moving and the geographic reach of their moves? Third, do distance, wage differences, and immigrant-network differences shape destination choices differently across generations and skill groups?

To answer these questions, I combine repeated cross-sections from the Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC) with state-level information from the American Community Survey. Parental-birthplace information in the CPS allows me to distinguish among foreign-born workers, US-born children of immigrants, and US-born workers whose parents were also born in the United States. I first estimate differences in mobility probabilities at multiple geographic scales. I then use a gravity model of bilateral interstate migration flows to examine how distance and destination characteristics affect migration across generations and skill groups. Economic and network characteristics enter the gravity specification as differences between the destination and the origin.

The results reveal that intergenerational assimilation in spatial mobility depends on the geographic margin under consideration. At the interstate level, second-generation workers have mobility rates similar to those of US-born workers with US-born parents, whereas foreign-born workers are more likely to move. At finer geographic scales, however, the second generation is less mobile than both comparison groups. First-generation respondents have the highest within-county mobility, whereas respondents with US-born parents have the highest cross-county mobility within states. These findings reject a simple characterization of the second generation as either uniformly native-like or uniformly similar to the foreign-born.

The gravity estimates reveal an additional distinction between the probability and geographic reach of mobility. Conditional on moving across states, high-skilled second-generation workers exhibit the weakest estimated distance decay. Their migration flows are therefore less geographically constrained than those of comparable US-born workers with US-born parents. Formal coefficient tests reject equality between the second-generation and native distance coefficients. The evidence consequently identifies a specific difference between the second generation and natives, rather than establishing a complete ranking of all three groups.

This result shows why interstate mobility rates alone provide an incomplete account of spatial assimilation. Although high-skilled second-generation workers are no more likely than comparable natives to move across states, once they move, their destination choices cover a geographically broader range. Similarities at the extensive margin can

therefore coexist with economically meaningful differences in spatial flexibility. Among high-skilled movers, first-generation flows are positively associated with destinations offering a larger foreign-born wage premium, whereas the corresponding coefficients for second-generation and native-parentage movers are not statistically significant. This pattern is consistent with economic opportunities playing a more important role in the destination choices of workers operating in geographically extensive labor markets.

The paper makes three contributions. First, it extends the literature on inter-generational immigrant assimilation by examining spatial mobility as a mechanism through which workers gain access to geographically distributed economic opportunities. Second, it contributes to the internal-migration literature by separating the probability of moving from the geographic reach and destination characteristics of migration. This distinction reveals generational differences that would remain hidden in analyses based only on mobility rates. Third, it connects intergenerational spatial assimilation with the literature on immigrant networks by examining how differences in network presence between destinations and origins shape migration flows across generations and skill groups.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 describes the data and presents the descriptive evidence. Section 3 introduces the empirical analysis of individual mobility probabilities. Section 4 presents the gravity model and the results for bilateral migration flows. Section 5 concludes.

2 Data

2.1 Data sources and sample construction

The individual-level analysis uses repeated cross-sections from the IPUMS Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC), covering 1995-2025.¹ The sample is restricted to employed respondents aged 25-59 with different full- and part-time work schedules, who are not currently enrolled in school and do not live in group quarters.

A key advantage of the CPS relative to Census data is the availability of parental-birthplace information. Although Census data provide substantially larger samples, the CPS separately reports the birthplaces of respondents' mothers and fathers, allowing individuals to be classified by immigrant generation.

¹Sarah Flood, Miriam King, Renae Rodgers, Steven Ruggles, J. Robert Warren, Daniel Backman, Etienne Breton, Grace Cooper, Julia A. Rivera Drew, Stephanie Richards, David Van Riper, and Kari C.W. Williams. IPUMS CPS: Version 13.0 [dataset]. Minneapolis, MN: IPUMS, 2025. <https://doi.org/10.18128/D030.V13.0>

State level characteristics are derived from the American Community Survey and properly aggregated. Person weights are used both to aggregate the ACS micro-data to the state level and in the descriptive and econometric analyses.

The annual ACS samples are pooled over 2000–2024, while the overall study period is determined by the availability of the CPS data.²

2.2 Variables and analytical samples

The two blocks of analysis, the linear probability and gravity models, are estimated with a series of variables obtained from the data.

The first set of variables measures geographic mobility at different spatial and temporal scales. The interstate-mobility indicator equals one when the respondent’s current state of residence differs from the state reported one year earlier. CPS migration-status variables identify whether respondents moved within the same county or across county boundaries. However, the restricted geographic identifiers do not permit the origin and destination counties themselves to be observed consistently. As a robustness exercise, I construct analogous interstate- and division-mobility indicators over a five-year interval. These outcomes are available only in the 1995, 2005, 2015, 2020, and 2025 waves. Respondents who were residing abroad one or five years before the survey are excluded from the corresponding domestic-mobility sample.

Second, each respondent is assigned to an immigrant-generation category according to the following rules: first-generation migrants are respondents classified as foreign-born in the CPS. Second-generation migrants are individuals who are US-born and have at least one foreign-born parent. Lastly, US-born respondents with two US-born parents are classified as third-and-higher generation individuals. For brevity, this group is labelled “natives” in the tables.

Workers with a bachelor’s degree or higher are classified as high-skilled.

Migration flow data have been aggregated from the CPS sample. The bilateral dataset contains all eligible interstate origin-destination corridors. Positive flows are constructed by summing person weights among interstate movers, while corridors with no observed movers are retained as zero-flow observations. Bilateral distance is measured as the great-circle distance between the population-weighted centroids of the origin and destination states.

The gravity analysis combines the CPS migration flows with state-year economic and demographic characteristics constructed from the ACS. Section 4 describes the

²Steven Ruggles, Sarah Flood, Matthew Sobek, Daniel Backman, Grace Cooper, Julia A. Rivera Drew, Stephanie Richards, Renae Rodgers, Jonathan Schroeder, and Kari C.W. Williams. IPUMS USA: Version 16.0 [dataset]. Minneapolis, MN: IPUMS, 2025. <https://doi.org/10.18128/D010.V16.0>

construction and economic interpretation of these variables and explains how they enter the estimating equation.

2.3 Descriptive evidence

Table 1 reports descriptive statistics conditional on skill level and immigrant-generation.

Table 1: Sample description

Characteristic	First gen (born abroad)	Second gen (at least 1 foreign born parent)	Native
Panel A: Low-skill (less than college)			
N	231,390	73,985	959,575
Age (Years)	41 (9)	39 (10)	42 (9)
Years of education	10.56 (3.29)	12.46 (1.41)	12.49 (1.16)
Total wage (2010 USD)	28,354 (34,710)	36,887 (38,618)	36,604 (38,291)
Sex			
male	(58%) 134,517	(54%) 40,005	(52%) 501,222
female	(42%) 96,873	(46%) 33,980	(48%) 458,353
Ethnicity			
White non-Hispanic	(13%) 29,988	(39%) 28,430	(78%) 729,099
Black non-Hispanic	(6.6%) 15,114	(3.0%) 2,228	(13%) 120,532
Asian non-Hispanic	(16%) 36,360	(9.3%) 6,783	(1.2%) 11,383
Mexican Hispanic	(41%) 95,606	(37%) 27,427	(4.5%) 41,960
Hispanic non-Mexican	(23%) 53,537	(12%) 8,454	(3.2%) 30,074
Unknown	785	663	26,527
Panel B: High-skill (college graduate or more)			
N	111,489	54,444	538,398
Age (Years)	42 (9)	40 (10)	42 (9)
Years of education	17.05 (1.35)	16.93 (1.28)	16.82 (1.20)
Total wage (2010 USD)	69,966 (78,815)	71,845 (76,217)	68,628 (75,118)
Sex			
male	(54%) 59,661	(49%) 26,834	(49%) 264,408
female	(46%) 51,828	(51%) 27,610	(51%) 273,990
Ethnicity			
White non-Hispanic	(28%) 30,944	(50%) 27,141	(87%) 460,914
Black non-Hispanic	(7.8%) 8,658	(4.3%) 2,345	(7.7%) 40,952
Asian non-Hispanic	(43%) 48,040	(21%) 11,287	(1.5%) 8,035
Mexican Hispanic	(7.1%) 7,835	(13%) 7,184	(2.0%) 10,639
Hispanic non-Mexican	(14%) 15,439	(11%) 6,106	(1.9%) 9,991
Unknown	573	381	7,867

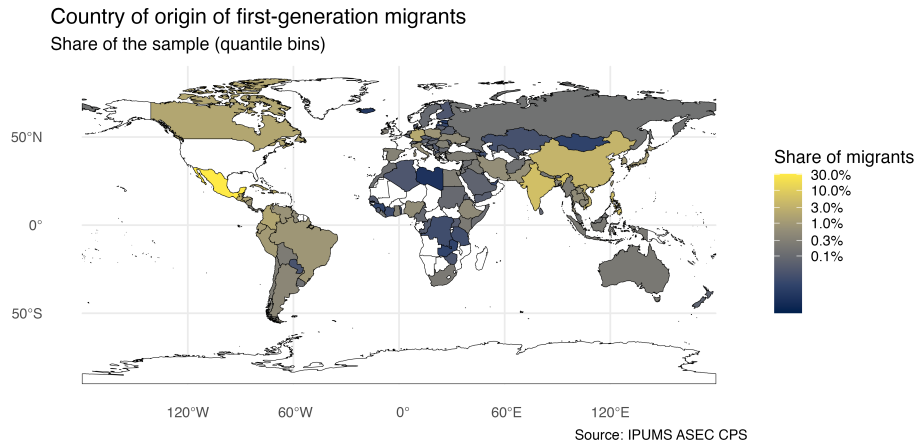
¹ Mean (SD); (%) n

Notes: The table reports descriptive statistics by skill level and immigrant generation. Means and standard deviations (in parentheses) are reported for continuous variables; percentages and counts are reported for categorical variables.

Second-generation respondents account for 6.52 percent of the sample, making them the smallest of the three generational groups. Within each skill group, they are younger than respondents with US-born parents but have similar annual wage and salary income. Overall, their socioeconomic profile is closer to that of respondents with US-born parents than to that of first-generation immigrants.

Ethnic composition differs substantially across generations and skill groups. Mexican Hispanics account for the largest share of lower-skilled first-generation workers, whereas Asian workers constitute the largest group among high-skilled first-generation workers Postel 2026. These differences motivate the inclusion of origin-specific network measures in the gravity analysis.

Figure 1: Distribution of first-generation immigrants by country of birth



Notes: Sample restricted to first-generation (foreign-born) respondents. Country of birth is matched to ISO3 codes; historical or sub-national codes no longer in use (e.g., Czechoslovakia, Yugoslavia, England/Scotland/Wales/Northern Ireland, the Azores) are manually mapped to their present-day country. Shares are computed over the total first-generation sample and weighted by ASEC sample weights; the color scale uses a $\log_{10}$ transformation to accommodate the highly skewed distribution of origin countries.

Table 2 reports weighted unconditional mobility rates and mean bilateral distances in km among interstate movers, providing preliminary evidence on the extensive and distance margins of mobility. The statistics distinguish within-county moves, cross-county moves within the same state, and interstate moves. They describe raw differences across groups and do not adjust for differences in demographic composition, geographic location, or year of observation.

Second-generation interstate movers have the largest unconditional mean distance in both skill groups. By contrast, the unconditional mobility rates do not produce a uniform ranking across generations: their ordering varies with the geographic margin and skill group. Because these comparisons do not account for origin composition or other covariates, the following sections examine whether the patterns persist conditionally.

3 Mobility differences across generations

This section estimates conditional differences in mobility probabilities across immigrant generations. It examines whether generational mobility gaps vary across geographic margins and skill groups. These estimates are descriptive and do not identify the causal effect of immigrant background on mobility.

Table 2: Mobility rates and distances

	First gen	Second gen	Native
Panel A: Low-skill (less than college)			
N (1-year sample)	231,390	73,985	959,575
State move (%)	1.33	1.50	1.58
Within-county move (%)	9.51	8.64	8.37
Cross-county, within-state move (%)	2.04	2.29	2.78
N (5-year sample)	32,548	11,709	139,559
State move 5 yr (%)	4.21	4.44	4.66
Division move 5 yr (%)	3.18	3.74	3.82
N (interstate movers)	3,046	1,047	15,166
Avg. distance (km)	1379.0	1413.3	1182.8
Panel B: High-skill (college graduate or more)			
N (1-year sample)	111,489	54,444	538,398
State move (%)	2.46	2.12	2.23
Within-county move (%)	8.03	7.54	6.85
Cross-county, within-state move (%)	2.56	2.66	2.80
N (5-year sample)	16,811	8,844	81,823
State move 5 yr (%)	8.97	7.67	7.67
Division move 5 yr (%)	7.25	6.44	6.17
N (interstate movers)	2,701	1,240	11,738
Avg. distance (km)	1450.5	1492.4	1303.8

Notes: Weighted (ASEC sample weight) unconditional mobility rates and mean bilateral distances among interstate movers, by skill level and immigrant generation, pooling all survey years. State move, within-county move, and cross-county within-state move are one-year CPS migration-status indicators; state move (5 yr) and division move (5 yr) are the analogous five-year indicators, available only in the 1995, 2005, 2015, 2020 and 2025 waves. Avg. distance (km) is the mean geodesic distance among interstate movers. Raw differences across groups; not adjusted for demographic composition, geographic location, or year of observation.

Section 4 subsequently turns to the destination-choice margin, conditional on interstate migration.

3.1 Empirical specification

The baseline specification is:

$$Y_{ist}^m = \alpha^m + \sum_{g \in \{1,2\}} \beta_g^m 1\{G_i = g\} + X'_{it} \gamma^m + \lambda_s^m + \tau_t^m + \varepsilon_{ist}^m, \quad (1)$$

where m indicates the geographic scale, $G_i \in \{1, 2\}$ identifies 1st and 2nd generation with natives as baseline, X_{it} contains individual controls, λ_s^m absorbs current state fixed-effect and τ_t^m time fixed-effect. The estimation pipeline includes CPS sample weights, clustered standard errors at the household level. Individual controls include years of education, nonlinear age effects and gender. The set of movers is relatively small. For ease of interpretation, the estimated coefficients and standard errors reported in the table are multiplied by 100. Thus, coefficients can be interpreted as

percentage-point changes in the outcome associated with a one-unit increase in the corresponding regressor.

An additional specification allows the generational mobility gaps to differ between high- and low-skilled respondents.

$$Y_{ist}^m = \alpha^m + \sum_{g \in \{1,2\}} \beta_g^m \mathbb{I}\{G_i = g\} + \theta^m H_i + \sum_{g \in \{1,2\}} \delta_g^m [\mathbb{I}\{G_i = g\} \times H_i] + X_{it}' \gamma^m + \lambda_s^m + \tau_t^m + \varepsilon_{ist}^m, \quad (2)$$

where $H_i = 1$ identifies respondents with college degree or more.

3.2 Mobility across geographic margins

Table 3 reports the baseline estimates.

Table 3: Scale dependent conditional mobility rates.

Model:	State-move (1)	Infra-county (2)	Across-county (3)
<i>Variables</i>			
First generation migrant	0.4065*** (0.0405)	1.0483*** (0.0871)	-0.3061*** (0.0482)
Second generation migrant	-0.0382 (0.0534)	-0.7802*** (0.1100)	-0.5587*** (0.0642)
Years of education	0.1549*** (0.0052)	-0.1969*** (0.0109)	0.0568*** (0.0061)
age	-0.4804*** (0.0144)	-1.7146*** (0.0287)	-0.6915*** (0.0180)
Age squared	0.0047*** (0.0002)	0.0156*** (0.0003)	0.0067*** (0.0002)
Male	0.2816*** (0.0201)	0.0878** (0.0406)	0.1899*** (0.0246)
Mean dep. var. — natives	1.81636	7.81149	2.78434
<i>Fit statistics</i>			
Observations	1,969,269	1,969,269	1,969,269
R ²	0.01009	0.04771	0.01756

Notes: Clustered (household) standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Linear probability model of equation (1). The outcome in Column 1 is an interstate (state) move; Column 2 is a within-county move; Column 3 is a cross-county move within the same state, all measured over a one-year interval. Coefficients and standard errors are multiplied by 100 and can be read as percentage-point changes in the outcome. Natives (respondents with two US-born parents) are the omitted generation category. All specifications include current-state and year fixed effects, individual controls (education, age, age², gender), and CPS sample weights. A small number of observations with zero-weight are dropped from the estimation sample.

Columns 1–3 use interstate moves, within-county moves, and cross-county moves

within the same state as outcomes, respectively. Socioeconomic parameters are coherent with already well-established facts in migration literature: younger males with increasing levels of human capital are more prone to migrate in all three columns except for the education parameter in column 2.

Mobility rate differentials compared with native baseline are reported in rows 1 and 2. Going through the table by row first generation migrants are approximately 0.4 percentage points more likely to move across states and 1.1 percentage points more likely to move within a county, but 0.3 percentage points less likely to move across counties within the same state. One possible interpretation is that location-specific family or community ties affect short-distance mobility differently across generations. The present model, however, cannot distinguish this explanation from differences in housing, household composition or local labor-market attachment.

At the within-state margins, second-generation respondents are 0.78 percentage points less likely to move within counties and 0.56 percentage points less likely to move across counties than respondents with US-born parents. Their interstate mobility is therefore similar to that of the native-parentage reference group, while their within-state mobility is lower. Group rankings nevertheless differ across the two within-state margins: first-generation respondents have the highest within-county mobility, whereas respondents with US-born parents have the highest cross-county mobility within states.³ Pooling second-generation respondents with the native-parentage group would consequently conceal meaningful heterogeneity across geographic margins.

The first-generation interstate mobility premium remains positive and statistically significant across alternative fixed-effect structures, but falls from 0.41 to 0.11 percentage points when current-state fixed effects are replaced by origin-state fixed effects (Appendix table B1)

Table 4 reports generation-specific mobility differentials separately by skill. Within each skill category, first- and second-generation coefficients are measured relative to respondents with US-born parents.

Table 4 shows that the generational mobility differentials vary by skill. The first-generation interstate premium is larger among high-skilled respondents, as is the positive differential in within-county mobility. For the second generation, the interstate differentials remain small and statistically insignificant, whereas the negative differentials at the within-state margins are concentrated among low-skilled respondents. These results reinforce the conclusion that spatial assimilation varies jointly by geographic margin and skill.

³Unfortunately, the CPS does not provide the information required to estimate a home-state premium.

Table 4: Heterogeneity analysis

	State move	Infra county	Across county
<i>Panel A: First generation migrants</i>			
High-skill	0.5947***	1.5705***	-0.0244
Low-skill	0.2563***	0.7530***	-0.4588***
<i>Panel B: Second generation migrants</i>			
High-skill	0.0266	-0.1083	-0.3196***
Low-skill	-0.0740	-1.2794***	-0.8333***

Notes: Generation-specific mobility differentials implied by the linear probability model of equation (2), which interacts immigrant generation with a high-skill indicator. Within each skill group, the first- and second-generation coefficients are measured relative to respondents with two US-born parents. Coefficients are multiplied by 100 and interpreted as percentage-point differences. All specifications include current-state and year fixed effects, individual controls, and CPS sample weights. Significance stars are based on standard errors clustered at the household level; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

The gravity analysis provides additional evidence whether distance, economic conditions and network differences are associated with these generational patterns.

3.3 Longer-horizon mobility, life cycle and parental nativity

The mobility differentials documented above may not be consistent when looking at long-term mobility rates, or when taking into account the contribution of respondents' life-cycle stages.

Table 5 shows that the qualitative distinction between first- and second-generation respondents persists at longer horizons.

On the restricted set of survey years for which five-year mobility outcomes are available, first-generation respondents are 0.44 percentage points more likely than respondents with US-born parents to move across states within one year. The estimated gap is 1.24 percentage points when interstate mobility is measured over five years and 1.12 percentage points when the outcome is defined as crossing Census divisions. By contrast, none of the second-generation coefficients is statistically different from zero. Thus, the first-generation mobility premium remains positive across time horizons and geographic definitions, whereas average second-generation mobility remains statistically indistinguishable from that of the reference group. Because the outcomes and exposure periods differ across columns, the coefficient magnitudes should not be interpreted as showing that the relative mobility premium increases over time.

Table 5: Longer-horizon mobility rates

Model:	State-move (1)	State-move (5 yr) (2)	Division-move (5 yr) (3)
<i>Variables</i>			
First generation migrant	0.4433*** (0.0993)	1.2444*** (0.1795)	1.1232*** (0.1744)
Second generation migrant	0.1069 (0.1360)	-0.3489 (0.2241)	-0.2119 (0.2286)
Years of education	0.1427*** (0.0134)	0.5675*** (0.0234)	0.5353*** (0.0244)
age	-0.4410*** (0.0374)	-1.0189*** (0.0623)	-0.8653*** (0.0628)
Age squared	0.0042*** (0.0004)	0.0092*** (0.0007)	0.0078*** (0.0007)
Male	0.3771*** (0.0519)	0.6007*** (0.0878)	0.5382*** (0.0909)
Mean dep. var. — natives	1.81636	5.79967	4.76361
<i>Fit statistics</i>			
Observations	294,684	291,294	241,876
R ²	0.00999	0.03533	0.02200

Notes: Clustered (household) standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Linear probability model of equation (1), restricted to the 1995, 2005, 2015, 2020 and 2025 CPS ASEC waves, the only waves carrying five-year retrospective migration information. Column 1 reproduces the one-year state-move outcome on this restricted sample; Columns 2 and 3 use the analogous five-year state-move and Census-division-move indicators. Coefficients and standard errors are multiplied by 100. Natives are the omitted generation category. All specifications include current-state and year fixed effects, individual controls, and CPS sample weights.

Table 6: Household composition controls

Model:	(1)	State-move (2)	(3)
<i>Variables</i>			
First generation migrant	0.4065*** (0.0405)	0.4716*** (0.0407)	0.4504*** (0.0405)
Second generation migrant	-0.0382 (0.0534)	-0.0425 (0.0534)	-0.0533 (0.0534)
Years of education	0.1549*** (0.0052)	0.1504*** (0.0052)	0.1643*** (0.0052)
age	-0.4804*** (0.0144)	-0.3913*** (0.0152)	-0.3977*** (0.0153)
Age squared	0.0047*** (0.0002)	0.0036*** (0.0002)	0.0037*** (0.0002)
Male	0.2816*** (0.0201)	0.2624*** (0.0201)	0.2996*** (0.0203)
N. of children in hh		-0.2795*** (0.0120)	-0.2156*** (0.0128)
N. of children <5 yrs old in hh		-0.0973*** (0.0338)	-0.0423 (0.0339)
Married, spouse absent			1.8685*** (0.1462)
Separated			0.8784*** (0.0836)
Divorced			0.7240***

Columns 2 and 3 in table 6 sequentially add to the model life cycle controls, such as marital-status and number of children in the household. The first-generation interstate-mobility premium remains stable after controlling for children and marital status, while the second-generation coefficient remains small and statistically insignificant. Household-composition controls do not materially attenuate the first-generation mobility premium.

The native-like interstate mobility of the second generation is sensitive to parental nativity.

Table 7 uses a stricter second-generation definition, requiring both parents (rather than at least one) to be foreign-born.

Table 7: Alternative second-generation definition

Dependent Variable:	state_move	
Model:	(1)	(2)
<i>Variables</i>		
First generation migrant	0.4065*** (0.0405)	0.4028*** (0.0405)
Second generation migrant	-0.0382 (0.0534)	
Both parents foreign-born		-0.2368*** (0.0710)
One parent foreign-born		0.1624** (0.0739)
Years of education	0.1549*** (0.0052)	0.1546*** (0.0052)
Age	-0.4804*** (0.0144)	-0.4811*** (0.0144)
Age squared	0.0047*** (0.0002)	0.0047*** (0.0002)
Male	0.2816*** (0.0201)	0.2819*** (0.0201)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>		
statefip	Yes	Yes
year	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>		
Observations	1,969,269	1,969,269
R ²	0.01009	0.01010
Within R ²	0.00627	0.00629
Wald test: both- vs. one-parent second gen.	16.627*** (0.0000)	

Notes: Clustered (household) standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Linear probability model of equation (1) for the one-year state-move outcome; same specification as Table 3. Column 1 reproduces the baseline second-generation definition (at least one foreign-born parent). Column 2 replaces the pooled second-generation indicator with two mutually exclusive categories, both parents foreign-born and exactly one foreign-born parent; no respondents are dropped. The Wald test row reports the joint hypothesis that these two coefficients are equal. Coefficients and standard errors are multiplied by 100. Natives are the omitted generation category. All specifications include current-state and year fixed effects and CPS sample weights. A small number of observations with zero-weight are dropped from the estimation sample.

The pooled second-generation estimate masks substantial heterogeneity by parental nativity. Respondents with two foreign-born parents are 0.237 percentage points less likely than respondents with US-born parents to move across states, whereas those with exactly one foreign-born parent are 0.162 percentage points more likely. The equality of the two coefficients is strongly rejected ($p < 0.001$). Thus, the native-like pooled coefficient averages two opposing patterns rather than indicating uniform convergence in interstate mobility across the second generation.

4 Gravity model of internal mobility

Section 3 shows that second-generation respondents resemble the native-parentage group in interstate mobility but are less mobile at finer geographic scales. Those estimates concern whether respondents move; they do not reveal how interstate movers choose among destinations. Similar mobility rates may therefore conceal differences in geographic reach and in the economic and network characteristics of selected destinations. This section studies this conditional destination-choice margin using a PPML gravity model.

4.1 Theoretical framework

The origin and destination correspond to the respondent’s state of residence one year before the survey and at the time of the survey, respectively. Migration occurs between $t - 1$ and t . State characteristics dated $t - 2$ proxy the information available to prospective movers before the migration interval.

Migration flows are aggregated by origin, destination, year, immigrant generation, and skill group. Zero-flow corridors are retained in the estimation sample. The stay option is excluded because Section 3 already examines the probability of moving.

The estimating equation is derived from a random utility maximization (RUM) framework in the spirit of McFadden 1974, following the gravity implementation in Beine, Bertoli, and Fernández-Huertas Moraga 2016. The derivation motivates the use of the Poisson Pseudo-Maximum Likelihood (PPML) estimator (Silva and Tenreiro 2006) and clarifies which sources of variation identify the parameters of interest.

Let $h \in \{L, H\}$ denote the skill group. Because the gravity models are estimated separately for low- and high-skilled respondents, the superscript h indexes skill-specific utilities, flows, and parameters. For every time-varying state characteristic z , define the destination-origin difference as

$$\Delta z_{od,t-2} \equiv z_{d,t-2} - z_{o,t-2}.$$

Consider an individual i belonging to immigrant generation g , skill group h , and residing in origin state o before the migration interval. Conditional on making an interstate move, the utility associated with choosing destination $d \in \mathcal{J}_o$, where $\mathcal{J}_o \equiv \mathcal{S} \setminus \{o\}$, is

$$U_{iodtg}^{(h)} = V_{odtg}^{(h)} + \varepsilon_{iodtg}^{(h)}.$$

The deterministic component of utility is specified consistently with the empirical model as

$$\begin{aligned} V_{odtg}^{(h)} = & \beta_{g,\text{dist}}^{(h)} \log \text{Distance}_{od} + \beta_{g,\text{border}}^{(h)} \text{Border}_{od} \\ & + \theta_{g,\text{RAwage}}^{(h)} \Delta \log \text{RentAdjustedWage}_{od,t-2}^N + \theta_{g,\text{gap}}^{(h)} \Delta \text{WageGap}_{od,t-2}^F \\ & + \theta_{g,\text{density}}^{(h)} \Delta \text{PopDensity}_{od,t-2} + \theta_{g,\text{population}}^{(h)} \log \text{Population}_{d,t-2} \\ & + \rho_g^{(h)} \Delta \text{ForeignShare}_{od,t-2}. \end{aligned} \quad (3)$$

Here, Distance_{od} and Border_{od} are time-invariant dyadic characteristics. The variable $\Delta \log \text{RentAdjustedWage}_{od,t-2}^N$ is the difference in native real wages between destination and origin, while $\Delta \text{WageGap}_{od,t-2}^F$ measures the corresponding difference in the foreign-born wage premium. The remaining state characteristics capture differences in population density and foreign-born population shares. Log population enters in destination levels, consistently with the empirical specification.

The coefficients are indexed by immigrant generation and skill group. Accordingly, the specification allows geographic frictions, economic conditions, and immigrant presence at the destination to have different associations with migration flows across generations and skill groups.

Assuming that $\varepsilon_{iodtg}^{(h)}$ follows a Type-I Extreme Value distribution, the probability that an interstate mover from origin o chooses destination d is

$$P_{odtg}^{(h)} = \frac{\exp(V_{odtg}^{(h)})}{\sum_{s \in \mathcal{J}_o} \exp(V_{ostg}^{(h)})}.$$

Let $M_{otg}^{(h)}$ denote the total number of interstate movers belonging to generation g and skill group h who leave origin o in year t . The expected bilateral flow is

$$\mathbb{E}[F_{odtg}^{(h)}] = M_{otg}^{(h)} P_{odtg}^{(h)}.$$

Substituting the conditional-logit probability gives

$$\mathbb{E} \left[F_{odtg}^{(h)} \right] = \frac{M_{otg}^{(h)}}{\Omega_{otg}^{(h)}} \exp \left(V_{odtg}^{(h)} \right),$$

where

$$\Omega_{otg}^{(h)} \equiv \sum_{s \in \mathcal{J}_o} \exp \left(V_{ostg}^{(h)} \right).$$

Because

$$\log M_{otg}^{(h)} - \log \Omega_{otg}^{(h)}$$

varies only at the origin-year-generation level within each skill-specific sample, it is absorbed by the fixed effect $\alpha_{otg}^{(h)}$. The conditional mean estimated by PPML is therefore

$$\mathbb{E} \left[F_{odtg}^{(h)} \mid X_{odtg}^{(h)} \right] = \exp \left[\alpha_{otg}^{(h)} + V_{odtg}^{(h)} \right]. \quad (4)$$

The parameters are identified by variation across potential destinations within origin-year-generation cells. In particular, the origin component of every destination-origin difference is constant within these cells and is absorbed by $\alpha_{otg}^{(h)}$. Consequently, the coefficients on the differenced variables identify how migration flows respond to variation in destination characteristics relative to a given origin. The coefficient on $\Delta ForeignShare_{od,t-2}$, for example, captures destination attraction associated with relative immigrant presence; it does not separately identify the anchoring effect of immigrant networks at the origin.

Equation (4) is estimated by PPML. PPML retains origin-destination corridors with zero observed flows and does not require the dependent variable to follow a Poisson distribution. It requires correct specification of the conditional mean and avoids the inconsistency introduced by log-linearization in the presence of heteroskedasticity. Origin-year-generation-skill cells with no interstate movers do not contribute to the conditional destination-choice model, while zero-flow corridors within cells containing at least one mover remain in the estimation sample.

4.2 Baseline gravity estimates

Table 8 reports PPML estimates of equation (4).

The table combines by columns the two skill categorizations, and within each category PPML coefficient estimates are reported for the three generations.

State wage measures are constructed from the fixed-effects from a Mincer equation of log wages net of state renting costs. For further details on the variable construction

refer to appendix section C.2.

Distance significantly reduces bilateral migration flows across all immigrant-generations and skill groups. Among high-skilled respondents, however, the estimated distance elasticity is substantially smaller in absolute value for the second-generation.

Table 8: Gravity model estimates

	Low skill			High skill		
	First gen.	Second gen.	Natives	First gen.	Second gen.	Natives
Border	0.815*** (0.134)	0.454** (0.178)	0.825*** (0.096)	0.659*** (0.155)	1.084*** (0.187)	0.834*** (0.093)
Log distance	-0.656*** (0.087)	-0.821*** (0.111)	-0.788*** (0.076)	-0.454*** (0.090)	-0.299*** (0.074)	-0.578*** (0.056)
Rent Adjusted Wage	-0.069 (0.859)	-1.229 (0.807)	-1.900*** (0.720)	-0.553 (0.567)	-0.658 (0.804)	-2.246*** (0.420)
Foreign-born wage gap/premium	-0.011 (0.504)	-1.343 (0.842)	-0.638** (0.305)	1.329*** (0.357)	0.300 (0.676)	0.107 (0.208)
Population density diff.	-0.005* (0.003)	-0.011*** (0.004)	-0.006** (0.003)	0.000* (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)
Log population	0.767*** (0.059)	0.843*** (0.075)	0.662*** (0.035)	0.900*** (0.082)	0.853*** (0.077)	0.857*** (0.031)
Sh. foreign born	0.033*** (0.007)	0.040*** (0.006)	0.017*** (0.005)	0.041*** (0.009)	0.035*** (0.009)	0.014*** (0.005)
Origin $\times$ Year $\times$ Generation FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	94,320	94,320	94,320	99,024	99,024	99,024

Notes: PPML estimates of equation (4), estimated separately by skill group (columns) and immigrant generation (sub-columns). The dependent variable is the bilateral interstate migration flow, aggregated from CPS ASEC person weights. Log distance and border are dyadic origin-destination characteristics; the remaining regressors are destination-minus-origin differences in state characteristics dated two years before the migration interval (rent-adjusted wage, foreign-born wage gap, population density, and foreign-born population share), while log population enters in destination levels. All specifications include origin $\times$ year $\times$ generation fixed effects. Origin-clustered standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

The coefficient is -0.299 for second-generation movers, compared with (-0.578) for native movers. These magnitudes imply that doubling the distance between origin and destination is associated with an approximately 19 percent decline in second-generation flows, compared with a 33 percent decline in flows among respondents with US-born parents. A formal coefficient test rejects equality between the second-generation and native elasticities. By contrast, the second-generation coefficient is not statistically different from the first-generation estimate of (-0.454) . The evidence therefore identifies a specific difference between the second-generation and the native reference group, rather than a complete ranking of the three generations.

This result does not imply that second-generation respondents face a larger formal choice set or are more likely to move across states. All movers face the same set of potential destinations, and the extensive-margin estimates show that high-

skilled second-generation respondents are no more likely than their third-and-higher-generation counterparts to make an interstate move. Instead, conditional on moving, second-generation flows are less concentrated around the origin and extend over a broader geographic range. Intergenerational assimilation in spatial mobility is therefore margin-specific: the second generation converges towards the native reference group in the probability of interstate migration but not in the geographic reach of destination choice.

This pattern complements the literature on immigrant assimilation by showing that convergence in socioeconomic outcomes or aggregate migration rates need not imply convergence in spatial behavior George J Borjas 1992; George J Borjas 1993; Abramitzky, Boustan, Jácóme, et al. 2019. It also extends research on second-generation residential dispersion and location patterns by isolating the role of distance conditional on migration Ellis and Goodwin-White 2006; Goodwin-White 2007; Schündeln 2014; Braun and Görts 2025. The concentration of this result among high-skilled respondents is consistent with nationally transferable human capital and access to geographically extensive labor markets reducing the effective cost of distance. It may also reflect the intergenerational transmission of migration aspirations or information about distant opportunities. The gravity estimates cannot distinguish between these explanations, while Section 4.3 examines whether co-origin networks help account for the broader geographic reach of second-generation migration.

State-level wage opportunities are measured using the state fixed effects estimated from a Mincer wage equation, net of log average rents. The resulting index therefore captures differences in wage opportunities relative to state housing costs rather than differences in nominal wages alone. Among high-skilled respondents, the coefficient of the destination-origin difference in the foreign-born wage premium is positive and statistically significant only for first-generation movers. A 1 percent increase in the relative foreign-born wage premium at destination is associated with an approximately 1.31 percent increase in high-skilled first-generation flows. By contrast, the corresponding second-generation and native coefficients are not statistically different from zero.

The negative coefficient on the rent-adjusted wage index among native movers should be interpreted cautiously. Because the index is an equilibrium outcome, rather than an exogenous labor-demand shock, the estimates cannot distinguish the contribution of unobserved amenities, local sorting, or other destination characteristics correlated with wage opportunities. Border and destination population are both positively associated with migration flows.

The final row of Table 8 reports the coefficients on the destination-specific difference in the foreign-born population share. For both skill groups, the first- and

second-generation coefficients are positive, statistically significant, and larger than the corresponding estimates for respondents with US-born parents. Formal equality tests confirm that the first-generation coefficient differs from the native coefficient among both low-skilled (p-value = 0.0037) and high-skilled (p-value = 0.0011) movers. The same is true for the second-generation (p-value = 0.0005 and 0.0269 respectively). By contrast, equality between the first- and second-generation coefficients cannot be rejected for either low-skilled (p value = 0.307) or high-skilled (p-value = 0.708) movers. Among low-skilled movers, the first-generation distance coefficient also differs from that of respondents with US-born parents, although the remaining low-skilled pairwise differences are not statistically significant. Appendix table C3 reports the complete set of pairwise tests.

These results indicate that, conditional on interstate migration, flows of first- and second-generation movers are more strongly associated with relative immigrant presence at the destination than are the flows of respondents with US-born parents. This pattern suggests persistence across immigrant generations rather than convergence toward the native destination-choice pattern. However, the aggregate foreign-born share is a broad measure of immigrant presence rather than a generation-specific co-origin network. Its coefficient may capture social connections, but also immigrant-oriented institutions, information channels, amenities or other correlated destination characteristics.

Section 4.3 therefore introduces co-origin-specific measures to examine whether the baseline association is concentrated in networks connected to migrants' own family origins.

4.3 Co-origin networks

Table 8 shows that interstate flows of first- and second-generation movers are more strongly associated with aggregate immigrant presence than are those of respondents with US-born parents. The aggregate foreign-born share, however, cannot establish whether this association is specific to communities connected to movers' own origins. This subsection therefore introduces a matched co-origin measure and examines two distinct questions. First, does co-origin presence increase the attractiveness of a potential destination? Second, does it attenuate the effect of geographic distance on destination choice?

The analysis is restricted to first- and second-generation movers because a comparable ancestral origin cannot be assigned to respondents with US-born parents. Countries of birth are grouped into broad geographic regions using the crosswalk reported in the Appendix. First-generation respondents are assigned the region con-

taining their own country of birth. For the second generation, I use the country of birth of the foreign-born parent when only one parent was born abroad. When both parents were born in the same foreign country, I assign their common region of origin. Respondents whose parents were born in different foreign countries are excluded because they cannot be assigned unambiguously to a single origin group; they account for approximately 7 percent of second-generation observations.

For each state, year, and skill group, the co-origin share is defined as the percentage of ACS respondents aged 25–59 whose birthplace belongs to the mover’s matched region of origin. The measure is dated two years before the migration interval, coherent with the gravity setup. For first-generation respondents, it captures the local presence of individuals from their own region of birth. For the second generation, it captures the presence of immigrants from their parents’ region of origin and should therefore be interpreted as a proxy for access to a parental-origin community rather than as directly observed network exposure.

Migration flows are correspondingly disaggregated by origin state (o), destination state (d), year (t), migrant generation (g), skill group (h), and origin region (r). Denote the resulting bilateral flow by $F_{odtgr}^{(h)}$ and the matched co-origin share by $S_{dr,t-2}^{(h)}$. The estimating equation extends equation (4) as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E} \left[F_{odtgr}^{(h)} \mid X \right] = \exp \bigg[& \alpha_{otgr}^{(h)} + \delta_{dtg}^{(h)} + \beta_{g,\text{dist}}^{(h)} \log \text{Distance}_{od} \\ & + \beta_{g,\text{border}}^{(h)} \text{Border}_{od} + \rho_g^{(h)} \text{CoOriginShare}_{dr,t-2}^{(h)} \\ & + \psi_g^{(h)} \left(\text{CoOriginShare}_{dr,t-2}^{(h)} \times \log \text{Distance}_{od} \right) \bigg]. \end{aligned} \quad (5)$$

The coefficient $\hat{\rho}_g^{(h)}$ captures the association between co-origin presence and migration flows at the average distance. A positive coefficient indicates that movers are disproportionately directed towards destinations containing larger populations from their own or their parents’ region of origin. The interaction coefficient $\hat{\psi}_g^{(h)}$ tests whether co-origin presence changes the distance elasticity of migration flows. Because the baseline distance coefficient is negative, a positive interaction would be consistent with co-origin networks attenuating distance-related migration costs.

Table 9 reports estimates from the specification that includes the co-origin share without its interaction with distance.

Co-origin presence is positively and statistically significantly associated with migration flows for both generations and skill groups. The estimates range from 0.072 to 0.125. Since the share is expressed in percentage points, these coefficients imply that a one-percentage-point increase in co-origin presence is associated with approximately

Table 9: Co-origin presence and destination choice

	Low skill		High skill	
	First gen.	Second gen.	First gen.	Second gen.
Border	0.900*** (0.119)	0.523** (0.206)	0.593*** (0.123)	0.947*** (0.230)
Log distance	-0.802*** (0.095)	-0.981*** (0.125)	-0.639*** (0.074)	-0.513*** (0.131)
Co-origin share	0.072*** (0.010)	0.102*** (0.014)	0.125*** (0.023)	0.095*** (0.035)
Origin $\times$ Year $\times$ Generation $\times$ Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Destination $\times$ Year $\times$ Generation FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	41,944	41,944	54,556	54,556

Notes: PPML estimates of equation (5) omitting the interaction between co-origin share and log distance, estimated separately by skill group (columns) and immigrant generation (sub-columns) on the sample of first- and second-generation interstate movers matched to an origin region. Co-origin share is the ACS population share, in the destination state and year, of individuals born in the mover's own (first generation) or parental (second generation) region of origin, dated two years before the migration interval. All specifications include origin $\times$ year $\times$ generation $\times$ region and destination $\times$ year $\times$ generation fixed effects. Origin-clustered standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

7.5 to 13.3 percent higher expected flows. The magnitudes should be interpreted as conditional associations rather than causal network effects.

The point estimates do not produce a uniform generational ranking across skill groups. Among low-skilled movers, the second-generation coefficient is larger than the first-generation coefficient, whereas the reverse ranking appears among high-skilled movers. The common result across all four groups is therefore the positive association between matched co-origin presence and destination choice, rather than a monotonic decline or increase in network responsiveness across generations. This pattern is consistent with the relevance of origin-specific information, social connections, and community amenities persisting into the second generation.

Distance remains negatively associated with bilateral migration flows for both generations and skill groups. Although the point estimates display different rankings across skill groups, formal tests fail to reject equality between the first- and second-generation distance coefficients in this no-interaction specification among either low-skilled (p value = 0.265) or high-skilled (p value = 0.298) movers (Appendix D.4, Table D2). These comparisons concern the first and second generations within the co-origin sample and therefore do not overturn the difference between high-skilled

second-generation movers and respondents with US-born parents documented in Table 8.

Table 10 introduces the interaction between co-origin presence and log distance, reporting the full model of equation (5) in a compact four-column format for all four generation-skill cells. The estimated main associations between co-origin presence and migration flows remain positive and similar to those reported in Table 9. By contrast, the interaction coefficients are small and statistically indistinguishable from zero for both generations and skill groups. Joint tests fail to reject the null that both generation-specific interaction coefficients are zero among low-skilled (p value = 0.509) or high-skilled (p value = 0.902) movers. Equality tests also provide no evidence that the interaction differs between the first and second generations among either the low-skilled (p value = 0.469) or the high-skilled (p value = 0.984) movers; Appendix D.4 reports these hypothesis tests in full. Estimates of the geographical contributions remain stable across the two specifications.

The results therefore distinguish between two potential functions of immigrant networks. Co-origin presence is strongly associated with which destinations interstate movers select, but there is no evidence that it attenuates the effect of geographic distance. In particular, the weaker distance decay previously documented for high-skilled second-generation movers relative to respondents with US-born parents does not appear to operate through greater access to co-origin communities at distant destinations. Other mechanisms, including nationally transferable human capital, broader information sets, or the intergenerational transmission of migration aspirations, remain plausible explanations for their broader geographic reach.

Table 10: Co-origin presence and distance decay: full model with interaction

	Low skill		High skill	
	First gen.	Second gen.	First gen.	Second gen.
Border	0.899*** (0.118)	0.516** (0.210)	0.590*** (0.124)	0.945*** (0.234)
Log distance	-0.792*** (0.103)	-0.937*** (0.131)	-0.651*** (0.084)	-0.519*** (0.147)
Co-origin share	0.072*** (0.010)	0.106*** (0.014)	0.124*** (0.022)	0.093*** (0.035)
Log distance $\times$ Co-origin share	-0.003 (0.012)	-0.017 (0.016)	0.005 (0.012)	0.004 (0.020)
Origin $\times$ Year $\times$ Generation $\times$ Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Destination $\times$ Year $\times$ Generation FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	41,944	41,944	54,556	54,556

Notes: Full specification of equation (5), including the interaction between co-origin share and log distance. Appendix D.3 additionally reports a benchmark specification with only distance and border, and the no-interaction specification of Table 9, alongside this full model, for all four generation-skill cells.

Formal tests reject equality between the first- and second-generation co-origin coefficients among low-skilled movers, but not among high-skilled movers. Because the ranking reverses across skill groups, the estimates do not imply a monotonic intergenerational pattern in co-origin responsiveness.

5 Conclusion

This paper examines whether the distinctive spatial responsiveness of foreign-born workers persists into the second generation. It distinguishes among three margins of internal mobility: the probability of moving, the geographic reach of interstate migration, and the characteristics of the destinations selected by movers. Combining CPS ASEC micro-data with state-level information from the ACS makes it possible to compare foreign-born respondents, US-born children of immigrants, and US-born respondents with US-born parents while allowing these margins to vary across skill groups.

The extensive-margin results show that intergenerational assimilation depends on the geographic scale under consideration. First-generation respondents are more likely than those with US-born parents to move across states, and this difference is partic-

ularly pronounced among the high-skilled. The interstate mobility premium remains positive when migration is measured over a five-year horizon or across Census divisions and is not materially attenuated by controls for household composition. Second-generation respondents, by contrast, are statistically indistinguishable from respondents with US-born parents at the interstate margin. This average similarity, however, masks heterogeneity by parental nativity: respondents with two foreign-born parents are less mobile than the native-parentage reference group, whereas those with exactly one foreign-born parent are more mobile. At finer geographic scales, however, they are less likely to move both within counties and across counties within the same state. First-generation respondents also exhibit different patterns across these margins, combining higher within-county mobility with lower cross-county mobility within states. Convergence in interstate mobility rates therefore does not imply convergence across all forms of spatial adjustment.

The gravity estimates reveal an additional distinction between the probability and geographic reach of migration. Conditional on moving across states, high-skilled second-generation flows display a weaker distance decay than the flows of respondents with US-born parents. Doubling the distance between origin and destination is associated with an estimated decline of approximately 19 percent in high-skilled second-generation flows, compared with 33 percent among their counterparts with US-born parents. A formal test rejects equality between these two distance elasticities, although the second-generation coefficient is not statistically distinguishable from the corresponding first-generation estimate. The evidence therefore identifies a specific difference between the second generation and the native-parentage reference group rather than a complete ranking of the three generations. High-skilled second-generation respondents are no more likely to move across states, but, once they move, their destination choices extend over a broader geographic range.

The destination-choice estimates also provide evidence on the economic and network characteristics associated with migration flows. High-skilled first-generation flows are positively associated with destinations offering a larger foreign-born wage premium, whereas the corresponding associations are not statistically significant for the other groups. More generally, the wage estimates are mixed and should be interpreted cautiously because state wage measures are equilibrium outcomes that may also reflect amenities, sorting, and other unobserved destination characteristics.

Immigrant presence provides a more consistent pattern. For both skill groups, first- and second-generation flows are more strongly associated with the foreign-born population share at the destination relative to the origin than are the flows of respondents with US-born parents. The more detailed co-origin analysis shows that this result is not driven solely by aggregate immigrant presence. Destinations containing

larger populations from movers' own or parental regions of origin attract greater first- and second-generation flows, conditional on general destination attractiveness. This association is present in both skill groups and does not display a uniform ranking across generations.

The co-origin analysis nevertheless provides no evidence that these communities attenuate the effect of geographic distance. Interactions between co-origin presence and log distance are small and statistically indistinguishable from zero, individually and jointly. The evidence therefore supports a destination-attraction role for co-origin communities but not a distance-cost mechanism: co-origin presence is associated with where interstate movers go, but not with how far networks allow them to move. In particular, greater access to co-origin communities at distant destinations does not explain the weaker distance decay observed among high-skilled second-generation movers. Nationally transferable human capital, broader information sets, or the intergenerational transmission of migration aspirations remain plausible explanations, but the present analysis cannot distinguish among them.

Several limitations qualify these conclusions. The CPS identifies states of residence at the time of the survey and one year earlier but does not provide precise within-state origins or migration motives. The network measures capture the presence of broad co-origin communities rather than individual social connections, and their estimated coefficients represent conditional associations rather than causal network effects. Moreover, the analysis examines access to geographically distributed opportunities but does not estimate the earnings or employment gains realized after migration. Linking mobility histories to subsequent labor-market outcomes and more direct measures of social networks would therefore be a natural direction for future research.

Taken together, the findings show that the second generation cannot be characterized as either uniformly native-like or uniformly similar to the foreign-born. It resembles respondents with US-born parents in the probability of interstate migration, while remaining distinct in local mobility, in the geographic reach of high-skilled migration, and in the attraction of immigrant and co-origin destinations. Treating the second generation as part of an undifferentiated native population can consequently conceal an important spatial dimension of immigrant assimilation.

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A Data, measurement, and descriptive evidence

A.1 Variable definitions and timing

Table A1 documents the variables entering the gravity specification of Section 4, including their definition and the level at which they vary.

Table A1: Variable dictionary

Label	Definition
1. Outcome	
Migration flow	Sum of CPS ASEC person weights (asecwt) over respondents with STATE_MOVE = 1, non-missing generation and skill, grouped by (origin = MIGSTA1, destination = STATEFIP, year, generation, type); left-joined onto the full cartesian origin-destination-year-generation-skill panel with unmatched cells set to zero.
2. Geographic variables	
Log distance	Log of the geodesic distance (km) between origin and destination state 2020 Census population-weighted centroids of population.
Border / contiguity	Dummy equal to 1 if origin and destination state polygons share a border (sf::st_touches).
3. Origin-destination differences (destination minus origin)	
Log native wage level, diff.	Destination minus origin difference in the native (foreign = 0) destination $\times$ year $\times$ skill $\times$ nativity fixed effect from a Mincer log-wage regression (log_wage $\sim$ age + age ² + sex + educ), estimated separately for each skill type.
Foreign-born wage gap/premium, diff.	Destination minus origin difference in (foreign FE – native FE) from the same Mincer regression as wage_level_diff – i.e. a difference-in-differences of the immigrant wage gap.
Population density, diff.	Destination minus origin difference in ACS person-weighted population (age 25–59, all employment statuses) per km ² of state land area.
Regional immigrant shares, diff.	Destination minus origin difference in the percentage of the working-age population born in each of 12 birthplace regions (Table A2); estimated separately by generation.
4. Destination controls	
Log population	Log of ACS person-weighted population (age 25–59, all employment statuses) in the destination state-year-skill cell.
5. Fixed effects	
Origin $\times$ year $\times$ generation	Saturated fixed effect absorbing the multilateral-resistance term α_{otg} for every origin-year-generation combination (fixed three-way interacted FE syntax).

Notes: All origin-destination difference variables are computed as the destination value minus the origin value and are dated two years before the migration interval. Distance and border are time-invariant dyadic characteristics. The Continental US share is the omitted reference category among the twelve regional immigrant shares (Section 5.3; region definitions in Table A2).

Table A2 lists the 13 birthplace regions underlying the regional immigrant-share

variables in Table A1 and the co-origin regions used in Appendix D.

Table A2: Region classification

Region code	Region
1	North & West Europe
2	South Europe
3	East Europe & USSR
4	Mexico
5	Central America & Caribbean
6	South America
7	East Asia
8	South & Southeast Asia
9	MENA
10	Sub-Saharan Africa
11	Continental US (omitted category)
12	Outside continental US
13	Other regions

Notes: Thirteen-region aggregation of the IPUMS BPLD (detailed birthplace) classification, used to construct the regional immigrant-share variables of Table A1 and the co-origin regions of Appendix D.

A.2 Sample construction

Table A3 traces the sample from the raw CPS ASEC extract to each of the paper’s analytic samples, reporting the number of observations retained after every restriction, separately for the one-year domestic mobility sample, the five-year sample, and the interstate movers/distance sample.

Table A3: Sample construction

Sample	Total obs.	First gen.	Second gen.	Native	% retained
Base filters					
CPS ASEC raw extract (1995–2025)	5,570,690	722,849	604,727	4,227,117	–
1. Age 25–59	2,599,924	473,956	166,240	1,951,946	46.7%
2. Labor force restriction	2,011,279	351,812	131,973	1,521,685	77.4%
3. Not enrolled in school	1,985,335	347,319	128,930	1,503,304	98.7%
5. Sufficient parental birthplace info	1,979,553	347,319	128,930	1,503,304	99.7%
1-year domestic mobility sample					
6. Valid 1-year migration info	1,979,553	347,319	128,930	1,503,304	100.0%
7. Domestic 1-year mobility sample	1,973,733	343,293	128,680	1,501,760	99.7%
Data quality correction	1,969,281	342,879	128,429	1,497,973	99.8%
5-year domestic mobility sample (subset of the 1yr sample)					
8. Wave with 5-year info (1995/2005/2015/2020/2025)	294,684	51,836	20,698	222,150	15.0%
9. Valid 5-year migration info	294,684	51,836	20,698	222,150	100.0%
10. Domestic 5-year mobility sample	291,294	49,359	20,553	221,382	98.8%
Interstate movers and distance sample (subset of the 1yr sample)					
11. Interstate movers, valid origin/destination	34,938	5,747	2,287	26,904	1.8%
12. Interstate movers with valid bilateral distance	34,938	5,747	2,287	26,904	100.0%

Notes: Unweighted counts. First-generation migrants are foreign-born; second-generation respondents are US-born with at least one foreign-born parent; all other US-born respondents are classified as natives. Respondents whose parental birthplace information does not permit a generation assignment are dropped from row 5 onward. Respondents residing abroad one year before the survey are excluded from the one-year mobility sample; respondents residing abroad five years before the survey are analogously excluded from the five-year mobility sample, with their five-year mobility status coded as missing (NA) rather than as non-movers. Five-year mobility outcomes are available only in the 1995, 2005, 2015, 2020 and 2025 waves, which explains the much smaller five-year sample; the interstate movers/distance sample is small because only 1–2 percent of respondents change state of residence in a given year.

As discussed in Section 4.3, second-generation respondents whose two parents were born in different foreign countries cannot be assigned a single region of origin and are excluded from the co-origin gravity sample; they account for approximately 7 percent of second-generation observations.

Table A4: Second-generation sample restrictions for the co-origin gravity model

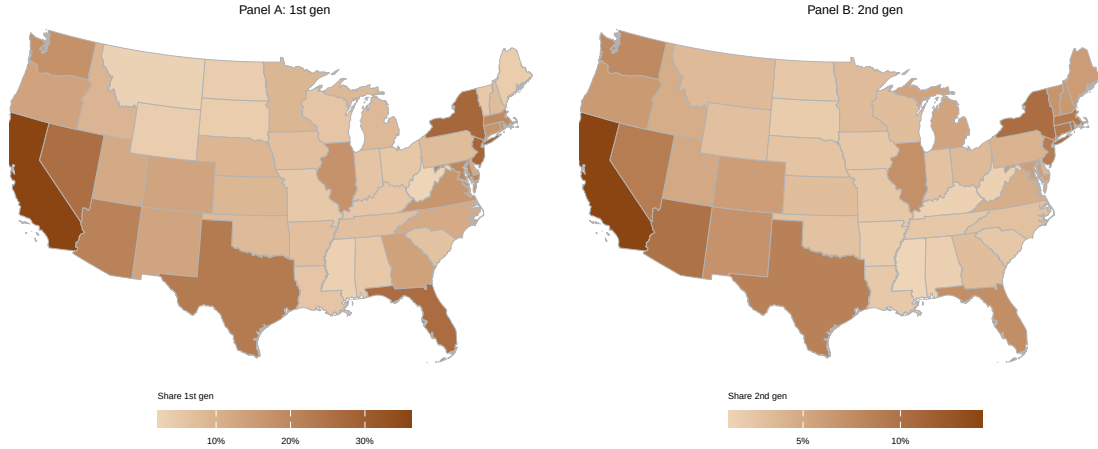
Status	Filter category	N respondents	Respondent share	Weighted share	N movers	Mover share	Weighted mover share
Included	Unique parental-origin region	86,743	91.81%	91.42%	1,367	90.35%	89.71%
Excluded	Parents born in different foreign countries	6,923	7.33%	7.67%	133	8.79%	8.76%
Excluded	Unique parental country not mapped to a region	684	0.72%	0.77%	10	0.66%	1.27%
Excluded	Unresolved parental birthplace	130	0.14%	0.14%	3	0.20%	0.27%

Notes: Sample: second-generation CPS ASEC respondents in 2004–2025 with observed skill, current state, and state one year earlier in the continental-US gravity geography (48 states plus DC). Respondents with one foreign-born parent are assigned that parent’s origin region; respondents with two foreign-born parents born in the same country are assigned their common origin region. Respondents whose two foreign-born parents were born in different countries cannot be assigned a unique origin region and are excluded from the co-origin gravity sample. A separate small group has a unique parental country that does not map to the regional classification; the final row collects respondents without enough parental birthplace information to construct `region_link`. N columns are unweighted CPS counts; weighted shares use `asecwt`. Movers have `STATE.MOVE` = 1. The PPML is estimated on aggregated origin-destination-year-generation-skill-region cells; the person-level counts here document the CPS observations underlying those flows.

A.3 Geographic and ancestral composition

Figure A1 reports the state-level concentration of first- and second-generation respondents across the continental United States.

Figure A1: Concentration of first- and second-generation migrants by state



Note: Panel A reports the share of first-generation migrants in each state’s sample population, aggregated across all survey years and weighted by ASEC sample weights. Panel B reports the analogous share for second-generation respondents. Alaska and Hawaii are excluded.

A.4 Support of the main gravity variables

Table A5 reports the distribution of bilateral distance among interstate movers, by generation and skill group, giving an economic sense of scale for the log-distance coefficients reported in Section 4.

Table A5: Distribution of bilateral distance among interstate movers

Generation	N (movers)	Mean	P25	P50	P75	P90	Share >1,000km
Panel A: Low-skill (less than college)							
First gen (born abroad)	3,046	1379.0	453.5	1064.7	1852.7	3392.5	52.0%
Second gen (at least 1 foreign born parent)	1,047	1413.3	547.0	1193.6	1764.0	3234.9	56.3%
Native	15,166	1182.8	395.4	819.7	1559.6	2694.2	42.5%
Panel B: High-skill (college graduate or more)							
First gen (born abroad)	2,701	1450.5	402.0	1147.5	2110.1	3652.2	53.8%
Second gen (at least 1 foreign born parent)	1,240	1492.4	480.9	1178.5	2110.1	3695.7	55.7%
Native	11,738	1303.8	446.3	909.5	1721.0	3178.0	46.3%

Notes: Sample: domestic interstate movers with non-missing origin, destination, and bilateral distance. Distance is the geodesic distance in kilometers between the origin and destination state population-weighted centroids. Mean, percentiles, and the share moving more than 1,000km are population-weighted; percentiles use linear interpolation on the weighted cumulative distribution. N (movers) is an unweighted count. Mean distances and total N reproduce exactly the corresponding figures in Table 2, confirming consistency with the main-text table.

Table A6 reports the analogous support of the co-origin share by skill group and origin region.

Table A6: Distribution of the co-origin share

Region	N cells	Mean	SD	P10	P25	P50	P75	P90	Max
Panel A: Low-skill (less than college)									
North & West Europe	1,076	0.34	0.19	0.13	0.19	0.29	0.46	0.61	1.24
South Europe	1,037	0.30	0.58	0.03	0.06	0.11	0.22	0.62	5.20
East Europe & USSR	1,078	0.94	0.59	0.41	0.59	0.78	1.08	1.80	3.46
Mexico	1,069	4.61	5.26	0.39	1.05	2.79	6.03	12.70	24.83
Central America & Caribbean	1,070	2.77	3.66	0.25	0.53	1.12	3.37	9.05	17.28
South America	1,058	0.97	1.56	0.08	0.16	0.35	0.86	2.76	9.29
East Asia	1,075	0.66	0.64	0.20	0.29	0.44	0.77	1.40	4.17
South & Southeast Asia	1,078	1.46	1.09	0.41	0.70	1.20	1.85	2.85	5.99
MENA	1,048	0.36	0.33	0.07	0.14	0.26	0.47	0.84	2.41
Sub-Saharan Africa	1,047	0.76	0.95	0.08	0.19	0.42	0.96	1.79	10.46
Other regions	1,074	0.34	0.29	0.09	0.15	0.23	0.47	0.74	1.84
Panel B: High-skill (college graduate or more)									
North & West Europe	1,069	0.79	0.46	0.31	0.46	0.72	1.03	1.40	3.29
South Europe	1,000	0.27	0.24	0.06	0.12	0.20	0.33	0.65	2.02
East Europe & USSR	1,078	1.43	0.77	0.59	0.90	1.25	1.80	2.46	4.09
Mexico	1,008	0.76	0.89	0.13	0.24	0.46	0.82	1.92	4.36
Central America & Caribbean	1,047	1.02	1.49	0.15	0.29	0.51	1.22	2.15	10.15
South America	1,053	0.95	1.11	0.21	0.37	0.61	1.17	1.94	9.46
East Asia	1,076	1.89	1.39	0.67	1.05	1.47	2.33	3.70	8.20
South & Southeast Asia	1,076	3.47	2.48	1.06	1.78	2.77	4.52	6.73	12.74
MENA	1,055	0.76	0.49	0.25	0.39	0.65	1.00	1.44	2.65
Sub-Saharan Africa	1,044	0.83	0.73	0.21	0.37	0.63	1.03	1.63	5.88
Other regions	1,076	0.65	0.39	0.24	0.37	0.54	0.88	1.16	2.80

Notes: Unit of observation: one destination-state $\times$ year $\times$ skill $\times$ origin-region cell with an observed ACS co-origin share, for flow years 2004–2025 and the continental-US gravity geography. The co-origin share is the ACS person-weighted percentage of the destination state’s age 25–59 population in the relevant skill group born in the mover’s own or parental origin region; it is dated two years before the CPS flow. Statistics across cells are unweighted because ACS person weights already enter the construction of each share. Regions without an assignable first- or second-generation origin in the CPS gravity sample are omitted. All entries are percentage points.

B Extensive-margin robustness

B.1 Alternative fixed effects

This is likely the most important robustness exercise for Section 3. Table B1 compares the baseline current-state fixed effect with an interacted current-state-by-year specification and, for the interstate outcome, an origin-state (pre-migration-state) fixed effect.

Table B1: Alternative fixed effects

Dependent Variable:	state.move		
Model:	State + year (1)	State $\times$ year (2)	Origin state + year (3)
<i>Variables</i>			
First generation migrant	0.4065*** (0.0405)	0.4127*** (0.0405)	0.1117*** (0.0345)
Second generation migrant	-0.0382 (0.0534)	-0.0408 (0.0534)	0.0400 (0.0473)
Years of education	0.1549*** (0.0052)	0.1549*** (0.0052)	0.1457*** (0.0047)
Age	-0.4804*** (0.0144)	-0.4794*** (0.0144)	-0.0442*** (0.0129)
Age squared	0.0047*** (0.0002)	0.0047*** (0.0002)	0.0006*** (0.0001)
Male	0.2816*** (0.0201)	0.2805*** (0.0201)	0.1967*** (0.0184)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>			
statefip	Yes		
year	Yes		Yes
statefip-year		Yes	
migstal			Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>			
Observations	1,969,269	1,969,269	1,969,269
R ²	0.01009	0.01222	0.15395
Within R ²	0.00627	0.00626	0.00114

Clustered (cpsid) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Notes: Outcome: state move (1-year); clustered (household) standard errors in parentheses, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Column 1: baseline fixed effects, current state of residence + year. Column 2: current state $\times$ year (interacted, more granular than Column 1). Column 3: origin state (state of residence one year prior to the survey) + year, replacing the destination/current-state fixed effect with an origin-state one.

B.2 Sample and period restrictions

Table B2 restricts the baseline sample to employed respondents, household heads, and years excluding the COVID-19 pandemic.

Table B2: Sample restrictions

Dependent Variable:	state_move			
Model:	Baseline	At work	Household head	Excl. 2020–21
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
<i>Variables</i>				
First generation migrant	0.4065*** (0.0405)	0.4077*** (0.0411)	0.4623*** (0.0497)	0.4129*** (0.0423)
Second generation migrant	-0.0382 (0.0534)	-0.0476 (0.0542)	0.0892 (0.0718)	-0.0117 (0.0565)
Years of education	0.1549*** (0.0052)	0.1556*** (0.0053)	0.1811*** (0.0064)	0.1562*** (0.0054)
Age	-0.4804*** (0.0144)	-0.4852*** (0.0146)	-0.5967*** (0.0190)	-0.4927*** (0.0150)
Age squared	0.0047*** (0.0002)	0.0048*** (0.0002)	0.0059*** (0.0002)	0.0048*** (0.0002)
Male	0.2816*** (0.0201)	0.2741*** (0.0206)	0.1553*** (0.0331)	0.2801*** (0.0209)
<i>Fixed-effects</i>				
statefip	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
<i>Fit statistics</i>				
Observations	1,969,269	1,907,316	1,082,439	1,863,141
R ²	0.01009	0.01017	0.01120	0.01025
Within R ²	0.00627	0.00634	0.00766	0.00643

Clustered (cpsid) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Notes: Outcome: state move (1-year); same specification as Table B1, current-state and year fixed effects. Clustered (household) standard errors in parentheses, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Column 1: baseline. Column 2: at work. Column 3: household heads only. Column 4: excludes the 2020–2021 CPS ASEC waves.

Table B3 restricts the one-year mobility model to 2004–2025, aligning the extensive-margin sample temporally with the gravity analysis.

Table B3: Robustness to the gravity-model sample window

Model:	1995–2025 (1)	2004–2025 (2)
<i>Variables</i>		
First generation migrant	0.4065*** (0.0405)	0.3270*** (0.0436)
Second generation migrant	-0.0382 (0.0534)	-0.0142 (0.0603)
Years of education	0.1549*** (0.0052)	0.1431*** (0.0059)
age	-0.4804*** (0.0144)	-0.3988*** (0.0160)
Age squared	0.0047*** (0.0002)	0.0038*** (0.0002)
Male	0.2816*** (0.0201)	0.2479*** (0.0229)
Mean dep. var. — natives	1.81636	1.55168
<i>Fit statistics</i>		
Observations	1,969,269	1,431,328
R ²	0.01009	0.00843

Clustered (cpsid) standard-errors in parentheses

Notes: Outcome: State move (1 year); Same specification as Table B1. Signif. Codes: ***, 0.01; **, 0.05; *, 0.1. Column 1: baseline (1995–2025). Column 2: restricted to 2004–2025, the years used in the gravity analysis. Clustered (household) standard errors in parentheses, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

B.3 Migrant vintage

Table B4 reports mobility rates by first-generation migrant vintage (new, early, and old migrants, defined by years since arrival), presented as heterogeneity within the first generation rather than as a central mechanism of the paper.

Table B4: Conditional mobility by migrant vintage

Model:	State move (1)	State move (5 yr) (2)	Division move (5 yr) (3)
<i>Variables</i>			
Early migrants	1.8070*** (0.1666)	2.8508** (1.2713)	1.6118 (1.1882)
Mid migrants	0.5067*** (0.0812)	3.4265*** (0.6676)	3.5256*** (0.7021)
Old migrants	0.2056*** (0.0463)	1.0975** (0.5336)	1.0149* (0.5255)
Second generation migrant	0.0071 (0.0624)	0.3713 (0.5845)	0.9351 (0.6071)
Years of education	0.1681*** (0.0061)	1.2754*** (0.0599)	1.2398*** (0.0647)
age	-0.4726*** (0.0166)	-0.9294*** (0.1538)	-0.6274*** (0.1570)
Age squared	0.0047*** (0.0002)	0.0107*** (0.0019)	0.0067*** (0.0019)
Male	0.2800*** (0.0242)	1.2254*** (0.2427)	1.0761*** (0.2600)
Mean dep. var. — natives	1.9798	15.3668	12.83705
<i>Fit statistics</i>			
Observations	1,560,161	94,835	77,122
R ²	0.01217	0.06081	0.02545

Clustered (cpsid) standard-errors in parentheses

*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Notes: New, early and old migrants are defined by years since arrival in the United States. Second-generation and native respondents are pooled in the reference category. All specifications include state and year fixed effects. Clustered (household) standard errors in parentheses, * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

B.4 Supplementary robustness exercises

Table B5 reports pairwise hypothesis tests of equality between the six generation-by-skill cells implied by the scale-dependent mobility model, separately for each geographic margin.

Table B5: Scale-dependent mobility: generation $\times$ skill hypothesis tests

	1st gen, High	1st gen, Low	2nd gen, High	2nd gen, Low	Native, High
Panel A: State move					
First gen, Low-skill	-0.6836***				
Second gen, High-skill	-0.5680***	0.1156			
Second gen, Low-skill	-1.0139***	-0.3303***	-0.4459***		
Native, High-skill	-0.5947***	0.0890	-0.0266	0.4193***	
Native, Low-skill	-0.9400***	-0.2563***	-0.3719***	0.0740	-0.3453***
Panel B: Infra county					
First gen, Low-skill	-0.7867***				
Second gen, High-skill	-1.6788***	-0.8920***			
Second gen, Low-skill	-2.8192***	-2.0324***	-1.1404***		
Native, High-skill	-1.5705***	-0.7838***	0.1083	1.2487***	
Native, Low-skill	-1.5398***	-0.7530***	0.1390	1.2794***	0.0307
Panel C: Across county					
First gen, Low-skill	-0.3812***				
Second gen, High-skill	-0.2952**	0.0861			
Second gen, Low-skill	-0.7557***	-0.3745***	-0.4606***		
Native, High-skill	0.0244	0.4056***	0.3196***	0.7802***	
Native, Low-skill	0.0776	0.4588***	0.3727***	0.8333***	0.0532

Notes: Each panel reports pairwise differences between the six generation $\times$ skill cells implied by a single LPM regression of the row outcome on generation, skill, and their interaction, with state and year fixed effects. Cells are model-implied differences (row minus column), each computed as a joint linear hypothesis test so that standard errors account for the covariance between coefficients; values are in percentage points, with significance stars from the joint test's p -value. Native, High-skill is the reference cell (zero by construction). Blank cells are the upper triangle/diagonal. Clustered (household) standard errors; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

C Additional gravity results

C.1 Construction of the gravity panel

Table C1 describes the composition of the gravity panel underlying the preferred PPML specification: the number of potential corridors, positive-flow corridors, and zero-flow corridors, separately for each origin-year-generation-skill cell.

Table C1: Gravity panel composition

Generation	Skill group	N cells	Positive flow	Zero flow	Share zero	Mean flow—pos.	Median flow—pos.	Total flow
First gen.	Low skill (non-college)	56,100	1,317	54,783	97.7%	2,508.3	1,778.6	3,303,398
Second gen.	Low skill (non-college)	56,100	623	55,477	98.9%	2,111.2	1,644.0	1,315,256
Native	Low skill (non-college)	56,100	5,238	50,862	90.7%	2,802.4	1,941.5	14,679,010
First gen.	High skill (college grad.)	56,100	1,551	54,549	97.2%	2,469.1	1,866.0	3,829,506
Second gen.	High skill (college grad.)	56,100	804	55,296	98.6%	2,003.3	1,631.6	1,610,632
Native	High skill (college grad.)	56,100	4,935	51,165	91.2%	2,810.5	1,962.8	13,869,961

Notes: Unit of observation: one origin-destination-year-generation-skill cell in the gravity panel. Years: 2004–2025 (destination/origin covariates lagged two years). States: 51 units. Directed corridors: $51 \times 50 = 2,550$ per year-generation-skill cell. Zero flow denotes a cell with no CPS-sampled interstate mover of that generation and skill group; the sum of weighted flow across all cells matches exactly the raw CPS-weighted count of interstate movers under the same restrictions. Mean and median flow are conditional on a positive flow.

C.2 Construction of wage measures

The rent-adjusted wage difference is constructed as the destination wage index net of average rent minus its origin counterpart. The wage component comes from the estimation of the following Mincer equation:

$$\log(wage_i) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 age_i + \beta_2 age_i^2 + \beta_3 sex_i + \beta_4 educ_i + \alpha_{d,t,\tau,f} + \varepsilon_i. \quad (6)$$

where d is the state, t is time, τ corresponds with the skill type and f is a foreign-born dummy. The state-year-skill-foreign-born fixed effect $\alpha_{d,t,\tau,f}$ absorbs the average log wage, net of age, sex and education, separately for natives ($f = 0$) and foreign-born workers ($f = 1$) in each state-year-skill cell. This specification identifies the average state-year-skill wage component, net of age, sex, and education, separately for native and foreign-born respondents.

The foreign-born wage gap (or premium) used in the gravity specification is constructed as the difference between the foreign-born and native fixed effects within the same state-year-skill cell, $\alpha_{d,t,\tau,1} - \alpha_{d,t,\tau,0}$, and the destination-origin difference in this quantity (“Foreign-born wage gap/premium, diff.” in Table A1) is therefore a difference-in-differences of the immigrant wage gap, not a level.

Finally, the real wage difference is obtained with the following manipulation:

$$\Delta w^{\text{real}} = (w_d - \log R_d) - (w_o - \log R_o) \quad (7)$$

where $\{d, o\}$ represents destination and origin respectively and R_s $s \in \{d, o\}$ denotes average rent.

C.3 Regional immigrant shares and interstate destination choice

For the regional-network specification, the aggregate foreign-born share in equation (3) is replaced by a vector of regional population-share differences:

$$\rho_g^{(h)} \Delta ForeignShare_{od,t-2} \longrightarrow \sum_{r \in \mathcal{R}^*} \rho_{gr}^{(h)} \Delta RegionShare_{od,t-2}^r, \quad (8)$$

where $\mathcal{R}^*$ contains the 12 regional categories included in the estimating equation (the 13-region BPLD aggregation of Table A1, excluding the Continental US region). The Continental-US regional share is the omitted category, since it is definitionally the complement of the other 12 shares. The coefficients $\rho_{gr}^{(h)}$ must therefore be interpreted as the association with migration flows *relative to* an equivalent difference in the Continental-US-born population share.

Table C2: Regional immigrant shares and interstate destination choice

	Low skill			High skill		
	First gen.	Second gen.	Natives	First gen.	Second gen.	Natives
Border	0.778*** (0.108)	0.365** (0.160)	0.755*** (0.082)	0.569*** (0.128)	0.880*** (0.207)	0.729*** (0.088)
Log distance	-0.746*** (0.083)	-0.898*** (0.104)	-0.885*** (0.055)	-0.597*** (0.065)	-0.444*** (0.080)	-0.678*** (0.053)
Rent Adjusted Wage	0.870 (0.714)	-0.446 (1.075)	-1.462*** (0.444)	1.182 (1.062)	0.467 (1.097)	-0.846* (0.485)
Foreign-born wage gap/premium	0.743 (0.496)	-0.452 (0.843)	-0.379 (0.330)	0.912** (0.378)	-0.614 (0.479)	-0.180 (0.161)
Population density diff.	-0.002** (0.001)	-0.002 (0.002)	-0.002*** (0.001)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	0.000** (0.000)
Log population	0.915*** (0.081)	0.936*** (0.090)	0.791*** (0.039)	0.880*** (0.096)	0.855*** (0.094)	0.855*** (0.037)
Sh. North & West Europe	0.698*** (0.136)	0.589** (0.270)	0.400*** (0.086)	0.006 (0.071)	0.069 (0.103)	0.121*** (0.032)
Sh. South Europe	-0.237*** (0.078)	-0.221 (0.136)	-0.161*** (0.042)	-0.278** (0.123)	-0.147 (0.157)	-0.324*** (0.062)
Sh. East Europe & USSR	-0.024 (0.048)	-0.061 (0.072)	0.027 (0.037)	-0.068 (0.044)	0.049 (0.072)	-0.071** (0.032)
Sh. Mexico	0.267*** (0.054)	0.300*** (0.049)	0.096*** (0.030)	0.725*** (0.228)	0.746** (0.298)	0.457*** (0.155)
Sh. Central America & Caribbean	0.021 (0.109)	0.094 (0.092)	0.097 (0.069)	-0.565** (0.234)	-0.391 (0.313)	-0.271*** (0.102)
Sh. South America	0.216** (0.096)	-0.131 (0.081)	0.025 (0.063)	0.235 (0.164)	0.046 (0.200)	0.145* (0.085)
Sh. East Asia	-0.678*** (0.148)	0.035 (0.194)	-0.564*** (0.113)	-0.071 (0.064)	0.164 (0.104)	0.009 (0.040)
Sh. South & Southeast Asia	0.125 (0.182)	-0.415* (0.213)	0.224** (0.098)	0.227** (0.100)	-0.260** (0.103)	-0.078* (0.047)
Sh. MENA	-0.254** (0.126)	-0.128 (0.129)	-0.208*** (0.047)	-0.022 (0.066)	0.031 (0.083)	-0.017 (0.034)
Sh. Sub-Saharan Africa	0.218*** (0.067)	0.119 (0.122)	0.056 (0.043)	0.068 (0.062)	0.024 (0.078)	0.003 (0.034)
Sh. Outside continental US	-0.011 (0.051)	0.190 (0.130)	-0.077* (0.041)	0.515* (0.268)	0.539*** (0.202)	0.169 (0.110)
Sh. Other regions	0.085 (0.102)	0.316** (0.128)	0.263*** (0.053)	0.256*** (0.071)	0.329*** (0.088)	0.186*** (0.034)
Origin $\times$ Year $\times$ Generation FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	94,320	94,320	94,320	99,024	99,024	99,024

Notes: PPML estimates of equation (4) with the aggregate foreign-born share replaced by the twelve region-specific population-share differences of equation (8) (region definitions in Table A2), estimated separately by skill group (columns) and immigrant generation (sub-columns). All specifications include origin $\times$ year $\times$ generation fixed effects. Origin-clustered standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

C.4 Formal coefficient tests

Table C3 consolidates the formal coefficient-equality tests discussed in Section 4.2, for both the distance elasticity and the aggregate foreign-born share coefficient, across the three pairwise generation comparisons and both skill groups.

Table C3: Formal coefficient tests

	Low skill			High skill		
	1st vs 2nd	1st vs Native	2nd vs Native	1st vs 2nd	1st vs Native	2nd vs Native
Log distance	0.1602	0.0442	0.7703	0.1412	0.1409	0.0001
Aggregate foreign-born share	0.3070	0.0037	0.0005	0.7086	0.0011	0.0269

Notes: Cells report p -values from Wald tests of equality between the row coefficient of the two indicated generations, estimated separately by skill group, from the baseline gravity model of Table 8. The Aggregate foreign-born share row reproduces the p -values reported in Section 4.2.

D Co-origin network analysis

This appendix is kept separate from the general gravity results in Appendix C because the co-origin network exercise is the paper’s most original contribution.

D.1 Origin-region assignment

Countries of birth are grouped into broad geographic regions. First-generation respondents are assigned the region containing their own country of birth. For the second generation, the country of birth of the foreign-born parent is used when only one parent was born abroad; when both parents were born in the same foreign country, their common region of origin is used. Respondents whose parents were born in different foreign countries cannot be assigned unambiguously to a single origin group and are excluded; they account for approximately 7 percent of second-generation observations (Appendix A.2).

D.2 Co-origin share construction

For each state, year, and skill group, the co-origin share is defined as the percentage of ACS respondents aged 25–59 (the same age band as the paper’s main analytic sample) whose birthplace belongs to the mover’s matched region of origin. The measure is dated two years before the migration interval, coherent with the gravity setup. For first-generation respondents, it captures the local presence of individuals from their own region of birth; for the second generation, it captures the presence of immigrants from their parents’ region of origin, and should therefore be interpreted as a proxy for access to a parental-origin community rather than as directly observed network exposure.

Because the co-origin gravity specification (equation (5)) saturates the model with destination×year×generation fixed effects, the co-origin share coefficient $\hat{\rho}_g^{(h)}$ is identified from variation in a mover’s co-origin share *across potential destinations*, within a given destination-year-generation cell, rather than from aggregate time trends in immigrant settlement.

D.3 Additional specifications

Table D1 reports the benchmark specification (distance and border only), the co-origin share without the interaction term, and the full model with the interaction, side by side, for all four generation-skill cells. The main text (Section 4.3) reports the no-interaction specification in full (Table 9) and the full interacted model in a compact

four-column format (Table 10); this appendix table lays out all three variants together for direct comparison.

Table D1: Co-origin share and distance decay: benchmark, no-interaction, and full model

	Low skill		High skill	
	First gen.	Second gen.	First gen.	Second gen.
Panel A: Benchmark (distance and border only)				
Border	0.836*** (0.119)	0.466** (0.194)	0.602*** (0.119)	0.937*** (0.230)
Log distance	-0.874*** (0.092)	-1.043*** (0.116)	-0.636*** (0.072)	-0.518*** (0.132)
Panel B: Co-origin share, no interaction				
Border	0.900*** (0.119)	0.523** (0.206)	0.593*** (0.123)	0.947*** (0.230)
Log distance	-0.802*** (0.095)	-0.981*** (0.125)	-0.639*** (0.074)	-0.513*** (0.131)
Co-origin share	0.072*** (0.010)	0.102*** (0.014)	0.125*** (0.023)	0.095*** (0.035)
Panel C: Full model, with interaction				
Border	0.899*** (0.118)	0.516** (0.210)	0.590*** (0.124)	0.945*** (0.234)
Log distance	-0.792*** (0.103)	-0.937*** (0.131)	-0.651*** (0.084)	-0.519*** (0.147)
Co-origin share	0.072*** (0.010)	0.106*** (0.014)	0.124*** (0.022)	0.093*** (0.035)
Log distance $\times$ Co-origin share	-0.003 (0.012)	-0.017 (0.016)	0.005 (0.012)	0.004 (0.020)
Origin $\times$ Year $\times$ Generation $\times$ Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Destination $\times$ Year $\times$ Generation FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	41,944	41,944	54,556	54,556

Notes: All three panels are estimated on the same co-origin gravity sample and fixed-effect structure. Panel A reports the benchmark specification with only log distance and border; Panel B adds the co-origin share without an interaction term (main-text Table 9); Panel C adds the interaction between co-origin share and log distance (main-text Table 10). Observations are identical across panels within each generation-skill column. Origin-clustered standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

D.4 Hypothesis tests

Table D2 reports individual and joint tests of the interaction terms, tests of equality between the first- and second-generation interaction and co-origin-share coefficients, and a test of equality of their plain log-distance coefficients.

Table D2: Co-origin hypothesis tests

Hypothesis	Low skill	High skill
Co-origin share: 1st gen. = 2nd gen. (full interacted model)	4.900** (0.027)	0.407 (0.523)
Log distance: 1st gen. = 2nd gen. (no-interaction model)	1.241 (0.265)	1.081 (0.298)
Log distance: 1st gen. = 2nd gen. (full interacted model)	0.679 (0.410)	0.983 (0.321)
Distance $\times$ co-origin share = 0 (1st gen.)	0.072 (0.789)	0.157 (0.692)
Distance $\times$ co-origin share = 0 (2nd gen.)	1.250 (0.264)	0.045 (0.831)
Distance $\times$ co-origin share: 1st gen. = 2nd gen.	0.525 (0.469)	0.000 (0.984)
Joint: distance $\times$ co-origin share = 0 (both generations)	1.352 (0.509)	0.206 (0.902)
Observations	41,944	54,556

Notes: Wald tests on the full model of equation (5) (Table 10), except for the no-interaction distance-equality row, which tests the corresponding coefficients from the no-interaction specification of Table 9 and is the test referenced in Section 4.3. p -values in parentheses.